
Point 1 — The £489,999 Question

Threshold avoidance and the Metropolitan Police’s Palantir “Unified Data Platform” pilot

Prepared for: the Office of Iqbal Mohamed MP (Dewsbury and Batley)

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Evidence: github.com/btmaffiliate/uk-data-linkage-disclosure

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A contract priced at £489,999 — £1 below the £500,000 MOPAC oversight threshold — meant a controversial Palantir pilot proceeded with no Deputy Mayor approval, no published decision, and no public scrutiny. This brief sets out the confirmed facts, the governance threshold (MOPAC Scheme of Delegation & Consent, Para 4.8), the procurement-law anti-avoidance rule (Procurement Act 2023, s.4 & Sch 3 para 4), and the questions to put. Confirmed facts, the questions they raise, and what still needs primary confirmation are kept separate. Analysis for scrutiny — not a legal opinion or an allegation of fact against any person.

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1. The point, in one paragraph

The Metropolitan Police ran its Palantir "**Unified Data Platform (UDP) Phase 1**" pilot under a contract reported at **£489,999 — £1 below the £500,000 figure at which, under the MOPAC Scheme of Delegation and Consent, the Deputy Mayor for Policing and Crime must formally approve the contract and a decision must be published.** The effect — whatever the intent — is that a live, controversial Palantir deployment that profiles the force's own officers proceeded **without the Deputy Mayor's approval, without a published Policing and Crime Decision, and without the public and London Assembly scrutiny that a £500,000-plus contract attracts.** The single most important question for Parliament and City Hall is therefore narrow and answerable: **was the value of this contract estimated and structured so as to fall below the £500,000 oversight threshold — and if not, how did a flagship AI pilot come to be priced at exactly £1 under it?**

2. The confirmed fact pattern

[confirmed] The contract figure and the threshold. The pilot ran under a Contracts Finder notice titled "Unified Data Platform Phase 1"; the original work was awarded at **£489,999**, which (in the reporting outlet's words) *"avoided hitting the £500,000 threshold for scrutiny from the Mayor's Office for Policing and Crime."* The pilot originally ran **1 February – 30 April 2026** and was **extended to 15 May 2026**; the Met declined to disclose the extension's cost, calling it *"commercially sensitive."* Source: *The Nerve*, "New fears over spread of Palantir's influence...", May 2026 — <https://www.thenerve.news/p/met-police-palantir-officer-ai-surveillance-misconduct-extension-contract-federation> (the outlet attributes the figure to the Met's own Contracts Finder notice).

[confirmed] What the pilot does. The UDP is **not** a crime database. It is a professional-standards / "continuous integrity screening" pilot that brings the Met's **own internally-held employee data** into Palantir Foundry to flag potential misconduct — analysing officers' **sickness and absence, overtime patterns, declared secondary employment, and data from work mobile phones and laptops including device geolocation.** The Met frames it as data it "already lawfully holds"; the Metropolitan Police Federation called it *"outrageous,"* citing "continuous 24/7 geolocation tracking." Sources: *Met Police news* (Apr 2026) — <https://news.met.police.uk/news/metropolitan-police->

strengthens-standards-using-technology-and-new-vetting-powers-508631 ; Silicon UK — <https://www.silicon.co.uk/e-regulation/surveillance/met-police-palantir-629642> ; The Nerve (as above).

[confirmed] The separate, larger deal that *did* go for approval was blocked. The crime-intelligence ambitions sit in a **different** proposal — "**Unified Operational Analytics (UOA)**," worth **£25.3m in 2026/27 with an optional £24.8m extension** (~£50m). That contract was put to MOPAC and was **refused by the Deputy Mayor for Policing and Crime (Kaya Comer-Schwartz) on/around 20–21 May 2026**, citing procurement-process failings (the Met having "only engaged with one potential supplier"). Palantir is reported to be moving to sue. *Sources: Novara Media (21 May 2026) — <https://novaramedia.com/2026/05/21/sadiq-khan-blocks-50m-palantir-ai-deal-with-met-police/> ; The Register (28 May 2026) — <https://www.theregister.com/public-sector/2026/05/28/london-cops-post-300m-tech-shopping-list-after-palantir-contract-blocked/5247685> ; Local Government Lawyer — <https://www.localgovernmentlawyer.co.uk/procurement-and-contracts/402-procurement-news/100588-london-mayor-blocks-50m-metropolitan-police-deal-with-us-tech-company-palantir-claiming-met-only-engaged-with-one-potential-supplier>*

The contrast is the story: the **£50m** deal that went through the front door was **stopped** for engaging only one supplier; the **£489,999** pilot — same supplier, same family of technology — went ahead **below the threshold that would have triggered the same scrutiny**.

3. Why £489,999 is the number that matters: the MOPAC oversight threshold

[confirmed] **£500,000 is a hard governance line.** Under the **MOPAC Scheme of Delegation and Consent (Paragraph 4.8)**, the **Deputy Mayor for Policing and Crime** holds delegated authority to approve, among other things, **the award of contracts with a total value of £500,000 or above**, requests to **go out to tender** at £500,000 or above, and **business cases** for expenditure at that level. Decisions at or above the threshold are taken as **published Policing and Crime Decisions (PCDs)** on the London City Hall website — the mechanism by which the public, the press and the **London Assembly Police and Crime Committee** see and can question MPS contracts. *Source: MOPAC Scheme of Delegation and Consent; MOPAC published decisions (PCDs) — <https://www.london.gov.uk/programmes-strategies/mayors-office-policing-and-crime-mopac/mopac-governance-and-decision-making/mopac-decisions>*

The consequence of pricing at £489,999. A contract one pound below £500,000: - requires **no Deputy Mayor approval**; - generates **no published PCD** — so there is **no public decision document**, no stated rationale, no recorded risk assessment in the public domain; - escapes the routine **London Assembly** visibility that PCDs provide; - and, because the *original* value was below £500,000, even the scheme's rule that **extensions** to £500,000-plus contracts need approval (where the extension exceeds 10% or 12 months) **does not bite** — which is why the undisclosed extension could be added without triggering scrutiny either.

In other words, £489,999 does not merely save a pound. It **switches off the entire public-accountability apparatus** that a £500,000 contract would have engaged.

4. The procurement-law dimension: structuring to stay under a threshold is prohibited

[confirmed — legal framework] Authorities must not manipulate or subdivide value to dodge thresholds. The pilot ran in 2026, under the **Procurement Act 2023** (in force from 24 February 2025). **Section 4** requires a contracting authority to estimate a contract's value using the Schedule 3 methodology and **restricts manipulation of the estimated value to avoid the Act's requirements. Schedule 3, paragraph 4** is an express **anti-avoidance** rule: authorities **must not artificially subdivide a procurement** to evade the rules, and must estimate the **maximum** value payable **including options to extend or renew**. Government guidance is explicit that "*rule-avoidance would never be a good reason*" to depart from aggregation. *Sources: GOV.UK, Procurement Act 2023 guidance — "Valuation of Contracts"* (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-valuation-of-contracts-html>) and "*Thresholds*" (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-thresholds-html>). The predecessor rule was PCR 2015 reg. 6(3).

Two points follow, and they are questions, not conclusions: 1. The anti-avoidance principle in national procurement law and the MOPAC £500,000 governance line are **distinct** (different figures, different purposes), but they share one logic: **you may not set or split a contract's value to escape the controls that would otherwise apply**. A flagship AI pilot landing at exactly **£1** under the local oversight threshold is precisely the fact-pattern those rules exist to catch. 2. If the **pilot, its extension, and the related operational work** were in substance one programme, the law required the authority to estimate the **aggregate maximum value** — which would plainly have exceeded £500,000 and engaged MOPAC approval. Whether they were properly treated as one programme is a question MOPAC and the Met can answer from their own records.

5. Why it warrants "going to town" — the propriety questions

- **Oversight was bypassed on the most sensitive possible subject.** This is not stationery. It is AI surveillance of police officers' health, movements and devices, on a US national-security contractor's platform — exactly the kind of high-risk processing for which public scrutiny exists — and it proceeded with none.
 - **The pattern looks like a foot in the door.** A sub-threshold "Phase 1" pilot, then a ~£50m "Unified Operational Analytics" deal. The small one slipped through below the line; the big one was caught and blocked for single-supplier procurement. That sequencing is itself a legitimate scrutiny target.
 - **Commercial-sensitivity was used to withhold the extension cost** — the very figure that would show whether the *total* crossed £500,000.
 - **No published DPIA, ROPA or ethical review** exists for the pilot (covered in the main pack), so the threshold avoidance also removed the document trail that a PCD would normally have surfaced.
 - **The Nolan principles** (openness, accountability) and the public-sector duty of transparency are engaged whether or not any rule was formally broken.
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6. The questions to put, and where

To the Mayor / MOPAC (Mayor's Question Time; London Assembly Police & Crime Committee): 1. What was the **total** sum paid to Palantir for the "Unified Data Platform Phase 1" pilot **including the extension**, and did the aggregate exceed £500,000? 2. Was the contract value **estimated in accordance with Schedule 3 of the Procurement Act 2023**, taking account of options/extensions — and on what basis was it treated as below £500,000? 3. Why was a Palantir surveillance pilot of this sensitivity **not** brought to the Deputy Mayor for approval, and **no Policing and Crime Decision published**? 4. Were the UDP pilot and the (blocked) £50m **Unified Operational Analytics** proposal treated as **separate** procurements, and if so, why was aggregation not required?

Written Parliamentary Questions (Home Office / Cabinet Office): 5. What guidance exists to prevent contracting authorities **structuring AI/data-platform contracts to fall below local oversight thresholds**, and how is compliance with the Procurement Act 2023 anti-avoidance rule monitored for police technology?

FOI (to the Met and to MOPAC): 6. The Contracts Finder notice and contract for "Unified Data Platform Phase 1"; the value of the extension; any internal value-estimation/threshold assessment; and any legal/commercial advice on whether MOPAC approval was required.

ICO: whether it has been notified of, or has reviewed, the processing of officers' special-category and location data under the pilot.

7. Honest caveats (so it can't be knocked down)

- The **£489,999 figure and the "£500,000 threshold avoided" characterisation are reported by The Nerve, which attributes the figure to the Met's Contracts Finder notice**. They are **not yet independently confirmed by me against the primary Contracts Finder record** (Contracts Finder blocks automated access). **Recommended:** confirm the exact figure and dates directly on Contracts Finder ("Unified Data Platform Phase 1," Metropolitan Police / MOPAC) before stating it as unqualified fact on the record. It is safe to cite **with attribution** as it stands.
 - The **extension cost is undisclosed**, so the **aggregate total is not public** — which is itself a finding, and the basis for FOI question 6.
 - **Intent is not established**. The contract came in £1 under the threshold; whether that was deliberate structuring or coincidence is **the question to ask**, not a fact to assert. The anti-avoidance law and the MOPAC scheme are cited to show **why the question is legitimate**, not to allege a breach.
 - This concerns the **Metropolitan Police / Palantir** policing pilot. It is **separate** from the Ministry of Justice's Splink programme (the subject of the main pack) — do not conflate them.
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8. Sources

- The Nerve — Met/Palantir UDP pilot, figures & extension: <https://www.thenerve.news/p/met-police-palantir-officer-ai-surveillance-misconduct-extension-contract-federation>

- Metropolitan Police — "strengthens standards using technology" (the pilot):
<https://news.met.police.uk/news/metropolitan-police-strengthens-standards-using-technology-and-new-vetting-powers-508631>
- Silicon UK — officer profiling detail: <https://www.silicon.co.uk/e-regulation/surveillance/met-police-palantir-629642>
- Novara Media — Mayor blocks £50m UOA deal (21 May 2026):
<https://novaramedia.com/2026/05/21/sadiq-khan-blocks-50m-palantir-ai-deal-with-met-police/>
- The Register — £300m tech list after Palantir block (28 May 2026):
<https://www.theregister.com/public-sector/2026/05/28/london-cops-post-300m-tech-shopping-list-after-palantir-contract-blocked/5247685>
- Local Government Lawyer — Mayor blocks £50m deal (single-supplier):
<https://www.localgovernmentlawyer.co.uk/procurement-and-contracts/402-procurement-news/100588-london-mayor-blocks-50m-metropolitan-police-deal-with-us-tech-company-palantir-claiming-met-only-engaged-with-one-potential-supplier>
- MOPAC decisions / Scheme of Delegation and Consent (£500k threshold; PCDs):
<https://www.london.gov.uk/programmes-strategies/mayors-office-policing-and-crime-mopac/mopac-governance-and-decision-making/mopac-decisions>
- Procurement Act 2023 guidance — Valuation of Contracts:
<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-valuation-of-contracts-html>
- Procurement Act 2023 guidance — Thresholds:
<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-thresholds-html>
- Home Office WPQ UIN 7092 (data categories) and answer: <https://questions-statements-api.parliament.uk/api/writtenquestions/questions?uin=7092&house=Commons>